





AN ART OF ABSENCE (Clockwise from left) A Case of the Broken Hands; It's Mine, No It's Mine, Now It's Yours, No It's Ours, Now It's Missing; Women Worshipping a Shiva Linga

ART

FOR GOD'S IMAGE



SHAURYA KUMAR'S SHOW TACKLES THEMES LIKE THE REPATRIATION OF IDOLS TO INDIA, BUT HE IS PLAYFUL THROUGHOUT

Working as a professor at Chicago's Art Institute, Shaurya Kumar, 43, enjoys a ringside view of sorts. He can see how visitors engage with artefacts in the Chicago Art Museum, especially the Indian Gallery. One Ganesh Chaturthi, he saw a group of women huddled around a Ganesh idol they felt they could recognise from their village. "They were about to pray to the statue, but the guard stopped them. He said what they were seeing is a stone sculpture, not their god." Kumar has seen similar scenes in Sarnath and Sanchi, too. These encounters made him ask: what happens to temples after their gods leave?

If, like Kumar, you count yourself among the faithful, then a visit to the Threshold Gallery in Delhi might prove to feel both entertaining and discomfiting. On display till December 20, Kumar's exhibition, *There is no God in the Temple*, is playful but urgent. Unmissable is the rather large chausar board with 3D-printed Buddhist and Hindu idols being used as pieces, and a large pair of dice determining their fate. Explaining the rationale behind 'It's Mine; No, It's Mine; Now It's Yours; No, It's Ours; Now It's Missing!', Kumar says, "Some of our associations with chausar come from the Mahabharata—the themes of deceit and cheating. So, it can also work as a metaphor for repatriation."

Elsewhere in Kumar's exhibition, we find the severed hands of divine beings. In his prints and paintings, we see women worship a space left hollow by Shiva's absence. We are made to witness a forest where Ram and Lakshman just were but have now disappeared. Kumar is inarguably doing something radical here. Art, for him, isn't just imitation or reproduction, it's also power and statement.

Not just looting, "the exhibition, in a way, covers all possible related aspects", says Kumar. He makes it possible to explain the absence of idols through several tropes and tricks. 'There is no God in the Temple' borrows its name from a line Rabindranath Tagore wrote, and much like some of the poet's works, Kumar's eponymous installation has many meanings. Staring at the words "*oi mandire kono debota nei* (there is no god in that temple)" painstakingly woven on a wall, Nandi's distress feels contagious. ■

Shreevatsa Nevatia

